230
CONFIRMED DEATHS; 200+ INJURED

1,592
PEOPLE RESCUED; 200+ MISSING

8,000+
SHELTERED IN 82 RELIEF CAMPS

1,167
RESCUE PERSONNEL DEPLOYED

Source: Government agencies, on Jul. 31



A SPATE OF BLUNDERS

- Rampant construction continues on hill slopes even as Meppadi was among the 18 ecologically sensitive zones identified by the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel in 2011
- A 2022 study in the *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health* pointed to the massive extent of deforestation in Wayanad–it lost 62 per cent of its forests between 1950 and 2018
- Studies at Cochin University of Science and Technology show that warming of the Arabian Sea is leading to the formation of deep clouds that bring heavy rains in Kerala within short periods. This increases the risk of landslides
- The Hume Centre for Ecology and Wildlife Biology at Kalpetta had alerted the Wayanad administration about the possibility of landslides in and around Mundakkai 16 hours before the disaster. Though a few families were evacuated, the measures proved to be inadequate

WHAT SHOULD BE DONE NOW

- More landslides are predicted in Wayanad, Kozhikode, Palakkad, Idukki and Kottayam. Giving heed to early warnings, all families should be evacuated from vulnerable areas
- An expert committee of ecologists, scientists and disaster management experts should chalk out effective preventive and mitigation measures for the future